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Straw Mulch Depth and Weed Emergence in Allotment Plots

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Abstract. We compared bare soil with straw mulch laid at three depths on allotment plots and counted emerging weeds and surface moisture over one summer.

Methods

Thirty plots were split into four treatments: bare soil, and straw laid two, five and eight centimetres deep. Weed seedlings were counted in a fixed frame every fortnight, and surface moisture was measured at midday.

Results

Counted over the whole summer and averaged across the plots in each treatment, a straw mulch layer 8 cm deep cut weed emergence by 54% compared with bare soil, while the 2 cm layer made no measurable difference. The deepest layer also kept the surface noticeably moister through the hottest weeks of the season.

Discussion

Depth matters more than material: a thin layer blows away or lets light through. Straw is cheap and easy to source, which makes it a practical first step for volunteer-run plots.